

works driven by machine-to-machine communication (thanks to the rise of Internet of Things) is increasingly going to collect complex, sophisticated data points about us, our surroundings, our world, and more to a level we can't even imagine and certainly can't comprehend on our own.

All of this insurmountable data when fed into machine-learning software and artificial intelligence are going to help us gain acute insights into pretty much every facet of our individual and collective lives. This sentiment is at the heart of Dataism, that it will provide us with a brand new point of view, a more logical and analytical philosophical argument about how decisions will be (or perhaps should be) made in the future. According to its early proponents – which are Silicon Valley executives and tech oracles – Dataism argues the universe to be nothing but flow of data from one form to another (much like the law of conservation of energy) and that organisms are nothing but biochemical algorithms manifested in flesh and blood. Much like the holy grail of physics which tries to bind all of the known and unknown universe into one, all-encompassing theory – the Theory of Everything – humanity's role in this constant flow of data is to make sense of the universe through a homogenous, all-pervasive data-processing system. And we are well on our way to realising this dataist world very soon.

DATA WORKS IN MYSTERIOUS WAYS

Our voracious appetite for creating and consuming data is at an all-time high. Every second, every minute, humanity uses, creates, saves and shares mind boggling amounts of data – more than it has ever done so since the beginning of time. Technology's all consuming effect is already evident, just pay attention to your daily routine and you'll realize just how much of an all-consuming this digital force is. Our digital lives are all about recording or capturing life's moments, uploading it online and sharing it with friends and on the Internet at large.

Just imagine how much data is created and shared by us. Every day we consume steadily increasing data bits through emails, online articles, phone conversations, video calls, etc., process all of it and send back newly created data through emails, articles and phone conversations. Just in the form of Whatsapp forwards on a daily basis – not just text messages but heavier images and even heavier video files. All consumed and shared within seconds with either an individual contact or hundreds in a closed group. If the message is particularly interesting it will be shared even more; if it's epic then it has all the potential of going viral and leaving a seismic impact on the data replication scale. Some of these activities seem devoid of conscious



All hail Data!

thought, relegated to mere twitches of conditioned muscle memory. We are all essentially being reduced to drones on autopilot, going through the motions of our ever-increasing digital indulgence. Like billions of tiny transistors in a giant computer chip that mechanically responds to external binary stimulus without any thought.

When we interact on Facebook everyday, post status updates, respond to friends' updates, share interesting jokes, memes or videos for others to see – or you do something similar on Twitter, Instagram, Snapchat or any other social networking platform of your choice – are you simply obsessively compulsively doing these things because you miss interacting with friends, or are you interacting online because that's the cool thing to do? Or is it simply that you're bored and going through the motions, for a lack of some-

thing better to do? We don't introspect every time we do these things, do we?

Have you ever wondered if the mundane things you indulge in online, maybe, have a greater purpose? Whether this digital addiction that we're all afflicted with fits into a greater scheme of things? We all already know the answers to these relentless questions. We don't really know where we all fit into this digital data web at an individual level and how our data connects with others and how this relentless flow of data contributes towards new innovations and disruptions that come about on their own; something that no one actually plans, fully controls or understands. And frankly, to be completely honest to you, dear readers, nor do we have the time to find out or ponder over such trivial day-to-day activities that we take for granted – because we're all busy being a part of the data-driven digital journey.

No one needs to understand anything, right? As long as you have a ton of email to respond to, scores of messages to laugh at and forward on Whatsapp, seek approval from online friends on Facebook, stick to your smartphone like a dog on a leash, it's all going to be fine. You'd have done your job to keep the data flowing. That's what Dataists (followers of Dataism) believe. Just as capitalist economists believe in the incredibly hard to describe invisible forces of free-market that forms the bedrock of the global economic system, so Dataists believe in the forces of dataflow and its increasing ability to shape our fortunes and become the source of all meaning in this world. In this data-driven world which is slowly coalescing into an all-encompassing, worldwide system of data points to analyze, given the right amount of biometric data and computing power, dataists believe that data-driven systems could understand humans far better than we are capable of understanding ourselves. A scary thought. Is it really?

DATAISM AND OUR FUTURE

Of course, Dataism can't thrive and be convincing enough without a few